

Note to IRB Reviewer(s)
IRBNet Protocol #2446127-1

*Cognitive Warrant: A Framework and Pilot Methodology for
Evaluating Semantic Alignment in Controlled Vocabularies*

Nicholas Meister (PI) | Faculty Sponsor: Dr. Krystyna Matusiak
Research Methods and Information Science, Morgridge College of Education
University of Denver

This application (Protocol #2446127-1) represents a new submission — not an amendment — and is a substantially redesigned and rescoped version of work previously submitted under Protocol #2415313-1. The earlier protocol described an ambitious multi-experiment confirmatory study that, on reflection, exceeded what could be responsibly executed and reported within the scope of a master's capstone project. The current application describes a pilot study with a rigorously bounded scope: proof-of-concept computational analysis, expert consultant validation of stimulus mappings, and pilot testing of two online surveys with 20 SONA participants (minimum reporting threshold: 15 participants).

I am aware that this application may be seen by the reviewer(s) of the prior application, and I want to address this directly. The current application reflects significant refinement of scope, methodology, and procedural detail relative to the earlier submission. The procedures described here have been developed with considerably more rigor, and the scope has been explicitly constrained to what is appropriate for a proof-of-concept pilot study. The full confirmatory study — addressing the complete stimulus set, fully powered experiments, and preregistered analysis — is deferred to a future application that will be submitted once the pilot data have informed the design.

I respectfully ask that this application be evaluated on its own merits as a new submission. No data collection occurred under the prior protocol and it does not describe the study proposed here. The current study is designed to qualify for exempt certification under 45 CFR 46.104(d)(2) and 46.104(d)(3) as detailed in the attached supplemental document, and I have endeavored to provide documentation that gives the reviewer a complete and accurate picture of what participants will be asked to do and how their data will be protected.

Summary. Protocol #2446127-1 is an independent new submission that supersedes Protocol #2415313-1. No data were collected under the prior protocol. The current study is bounded in scope, methodologically mature, and designed to qualify for exempt certification. The principal investigator respectfully requests that it be reviewed accordingly.

I note for the reviewer's context that I am scheduled to complete my master's program in June 2026. I have made every effort to ensure this application is complete and thorough, and I hope that the level of documentation provided facilitates an efficient review. I welcome any questions and can provide additional materials on short notice.

Nicholas Meister, PI
nicholas.meister@du.edu